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Grants Without Gratitude? EU Rural Development Funding and Institutional Trust in Poland

Poland has been one of the largest beneficiaries of the European Agricultural Fund for Rural Development (EAFRD), receiving substantial support to modernise its agricultural sector since joining the EU. While EU structural funds are often assumed to foster favourable public attitudes toward the polity, declining trust in supranational governance, especially among rural communities, suggests a more complex relationship. To address this puzzle, we conceptualize institutional trust in multilevel governance as shaped by overlapping mechanisms: material, redistributive, and generational, that influence attitudes toward national and supranational institutions in distinct ways. Drawing on individual-level data from the European Social Survey (ESS) combined with structural funding data from the European Commission (2008–2022), the analysis reveals heterogeneous, non-linear patterns across our estimations: moderate funding correlates with higher levels of institutional trust, whereas the lowest and highest allocations correspond to declining trust in the rural areas. These findings challenge assumptions of uniform positive effects, highlighting the region-specific nature of distributive policy and its impact on legitimacy across governance levels.

Keywords: EAFRD, Poland, institutional trust, European Social Survey, CAP, Cohesion Funding

Introduction

The European Agricultural Fund for Rural Development (EAFRD) is the second pillar of the EU's Common Agricultural Policy (CAP), which aims to finance development of the rural areas of the EU member states (European Commission, 2025b). It targets three major areas: fostering agricultural competitiveness, ensuring sustainable management of natural resources, and mitigate territorial disparities between rural communities (European Commission, 2025b). For Poland, in the 2014–2022 period, the four largest[1] areas of EAFRD funding in budgetary terms were general investments in physical infrastructure, farm and business development, payments for areas facing natural constraints, and the provision of basic services and village renewal in rural areas (European Commission, 2025c, p. 4). The EAFRD is therefore directed towards a group of disadvantaged individuals who might otherwise lack the resources needed for competitive and sustainable agriculture. At the same time, rural populations, among whom many of these beneficiaries are located, have been shown to exhibit lower levels of trust in both national governments and supranational institutions such as the EU, relative to their urban counterparts (Mitsch, et al., 2022).

Poland is an illustrative case of that puzzle: despite substantial and, as Table 1 shows, broadly distributed EAFRD funding, the EU's financial assistance has not translated into stronger pro-European sentiment (Rodríguez-Pose & Dijkstra, 2020). In rural Poland, where EAFRD funding is expected to be the most visible,

[1] More comprehensive list is presented in Table 1, in the Appendix.

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exposure has not prevented the persistence of sceptical attitudes toward EU integration, highlighting the limits of distributive policies as instruments of legitimation (Hartnett and Gard-Murray 2018; Paeth and Vogel 2024). Therefore, we face a disconnect, while the EU's funding succeeded in delivering tangible improvements, it did not necessarily generate symbolic loyalty (Capello & Perucca, 2019).

[Table 1. Frequency Distribution of EAFRD Funding Bands Matched to ESS Respondents by Voivodeship, Poland 2001-2022]

Table 1. Frequency Distribution of EAFRD Funding Bands Matched to ESS Respondents by Voivodeship, Poland 2001-2022

Voivodeship	Acronym	>40 mln	40–79 mln	80–119 mln	120–160 mln	>161 mln	Total number of obs.	Total absorbed funding (€ bn)
Mazowieckie Regional (Mazowieckie including Warsaw)	MAZ	1429	466	475	149	676	2,143	2.77
Lubelskie	LUB	1,068	145	436	92	596	2,337	2.44
Małopolskie	MAŁ	1,041	165	164	247	984	2,601	2.29
Podkarpackie	POD	1,344	306	324	356	912	3,242	1.68
Łódzkie	ŁÓD	584	302	223	46	329	1,484	1.61
Wielkopolskie	WLK	403	133	74	40	77	727	1.85
Świętokrzyskie	ŚWI	562	135	192	56	230	1,175	1.38
Kujawsko-Pomorskie	KP	672	244	179	20	252	1,367	1.23
Podlaskie	PODL	638	192	198	24	229	1,281	1.01
Dolnośląskie	DŚL	767	256	212	82	457	1,774	1.01
Warmińsko-Mazurskie	WM	496	190	85	39	125	935	0.74
Pomorskie	POM	746	299	230	0	237	1512	0.87
Zachodniopomorskie	ZPM	413	100	58	0	61	632	0.61
Opolskie	OPO	439	93	42	24	48	646	0.55
Lubuskie	LUBU	438	93	79	31	33	674	0.44

Own calculations using (ESS, 2008-2022; European Commission, 2025a)

The EU data on funding provide regional allocation of funds in millions of euros per each of the cohesion funds, which were meaningfully positively skewed (g1=1.36). The continuous variable of annual EU payments was thus re-coded into discrete categories to improve interpretability. The bands were determined by inspecting the histogram of the distribution, which provided an empirical basis for identifying natural breaks in funding intensity with small (<40 mln), moderate (40–119 mln), high (120–160

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mln), and very large (>161 mln). Recoding to such categorisation reduced the influence of extreme values which skewness approximating symmetry (g2=0.62) and thus stabilised the final estimates.

To better understand regional differences in the absorption of EAFRD funding over the period, we revisit Table 1 that shows the distribution of matched observations across funding bands and the total absorbed financing per each of the Polish regions. Mazowieckie absorbed the largest overall volume (€2.77 bn). Its region-year funding profile shows a concentration of matched respondents in the mid-range and highest funding bands, consistent with the region's strong administrative capacity. Lubelskie (€2.44 bn) and Małopolskie (€2.29 bn) follow, each displaying a relatively balanced distribution across funding bands, reflecting both agricultural intensity and effective uptake of rural development support. Podkarpackie absorbed €1.68 bn, with respondents appearing in both the lowest and higher bands, indicating active engagement despite a more modest total. Wielkopolskie (€1.85 bn) also ranks high, with a broad spread across funding bands that suggests a diversified agricultural sector and steady absorption. Pomorskie (€0.87 bn), Podlaskie and Dolnośląskie (€1.01 bn) occupy a middle position, with some matched respondents falling into higher funding bands. By contrast, Western regions such as Lubuskie (€0.44 bn), Opolskie (€0.55 bn) and Zachodniopomorskie (€0.61 bn) show substantially lower totals and a concentration in the lowest funding band, which may point to weaker absorption capacity or more limited rural demand. Overall, Eastern and South-eastern regions dominate both in total absorption and in the frequency of higher-band observations, reflecting stronger agricultural intensity and more proactive engagement with EU rural development instruments. Although absorption levels differ across regions, EAFRD funding in voivodeship confirms a broad national coverage, meaning that citizens across Poland have almost certainly encountered some form of EAFRD-funded investment since 2001. This widespread exposure matters because Eurosceptic attitudes are not evenly distributed across the country; regions with lower absorption or fewer visible initiatives may have had fewer tangible encounters with EU-funded rural development, while areas with extensive funding activity, especially large, highly visible investments, have been more directly confronted with the material benefits of EU membership. As a result, the geographic pattern of EAFRD implementation may intersect with, and potentially moderate, regional differences in general degree of trust to the EU, and satisfaction with multilevel governance.

By examining these patterns in depth, this study contributes to the ongoing debate on the role of the EU cohesion funding[2], and it's influence on attitudes towards the EU, in the following way. While most studies have concentrated on cross-country comparisons (Dellmuth, Schraff, and Stoffel, 2017) or the regional dimension of the support under the European regional cohesion policy (Bachtler, et al., 2018; Borin, et al., 2021), we deliberately selected a single country case: Poland, which has the largest agricultural sector among the EU's net-beneficiary member states, and we focused specifically on the influence of the EAFRD rather than other funding instruments[3]. This focus allowed us to analyse a context in which EU expenditure is

[2] Although EAFRD is formally part of the CAP, its rural development measures contribute to broader EU cohesion goals by supporting lagging rural regions, and as such EAFRD funding data is included in the EC's Cohesion Data portal.
[3] To avoid selection bias, we included other cohesion funds as controls.

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domain-specific and, owing to the country's net-beneficiary position, expected to be broadly advantageous for the public attitudes towards the EU.

The article is structured as follows. It begins with a review of the literature to establish the theoretical framework and presents the hypotheses. Then, it introduces the data sources, followed by the operationalisation of the key variables and explains the selected estimation method. The findings section presents results for both national and supranational trust estimations. The discussion links our findings with the theorised interlinkages, and the article concludes with insights on the broader implications for the EU legitimacy and the dynamics of institutional trust.

Theoretical framework

Institutional trust in multilevel governance is shaped by overlapping mechanisms that reflect how citizens interpret their relationship to various governing structures. We conceptualize these mechanisms based on the following three pillars: material security, redistributive role of cohesion, and generational dynamics, seeing for each to be influencing attitudes toward national and supranational institutions in distinct ways. Firstly, we argue that economic security reinforces confidence in political institutions by signalling their capacity to deliver prosperity (Hudson 2006; Brady, Verba & Schlozman 1995). In the Polish context, household income serves as a proxy for economic security, shaping attitudes toward both national and supranational governance. Higher income levels reduce vulnerability to uncertainty and foster positive evaluations of institutional effectiveness, thereby strengthening trust across governance levels, while economic distress is shown to have an opposite effect (Roth, et al., 2013).

Secondly, redistributive policies, while designed to promote cohesion, can paradoxically erode trust when their allocation is perceived as opaque or captured by elites (Acemoglu & Robinson 2001; Natili, Ronchi & Visconti 2023). Our expectation, supported by recent assessment of cohesion policy (Mendez, Bachtler & Wishlade 2025, p.69), is that limited visibility of the EU transfers impedes it being translated into symbolic loyalty. We also follow Capello & Perucca (2019, p. 641) who assessed that the unaddressed discrepancies in regional economy of residence are likely reducing trust in the EU institutions. This paradox underscores how the material standing can deepen distrust towards the EU (Vasilopoulou & Talving, 2024).

Thirdly, political attitudes are shaped by formative experiences, making generational socialisation a critical determinant of institutional trust (Geurkink, et al., 2024; Abramson & Inglehart 1992; Gonzálvez-Gallego & Nieto-Torrejón 2021). In Poland, older cohorts who experienced communism and early EU accession debates often prioritize sovereignty and exhibit scepticism toward supranational governance while younger cohorts, socialised during EU membership, display greater openness to multilevel governance and European integration (Valgarðsson 2024). These cohort effects reflect national identity as historically embedded: trust orientations are not only shaped by current material conditions but also by narratives of national autonomy and integration. Understanding these dynamics is essential for explaining why supranational trust diverges from national trust, even when both may be influenced by similar socioeconomic drivers.

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Building on these three pillars, we derive a set of testable hypotheses that directly reflect the theoretical arguments outlined above. The assumption about material security leads us to expect that income consistently enhances trust across governance levels. Redistributive politics suggests that agricultural transfers may paradoxically erode confidence in institutions, particularly at the national level. Generational socialisation points to potential cohort differences, with older citizens less supportive of supranational governance. Taken together, these perspectives inform the following hypotheses:

- **H1** Higher household income is positively associated with institutional trust
- **H2** Living in regions with greater agricultural financing intensity correlates with reduced institutional trust
- **H3** Older individuals exhibit lower levels of institutional trust compared to younger cohorts

Before presenting the data, it is also important to justify why analysis of institutional trust and agricultural support provided by the EU merits our attention. First, we ought to define the concept. Institutional trust refers to citizens' confidence in the competence, and responsiveness of political institutions, and is widely recognized as a signifier of support for broadly defined democratic values (Hooghe and Stiers 2016; Levi and Stoker 2000). At the national level, trust in domestic institutions reflects individual perceptions of government performance and accountability (Newton & Zmerli, 2011). As put forward by Warren (1999), political trust is enhanced by a rational assessment of whether institutions act transparently and respond to citizens' needs. At the supranational level, we follow Harteveld, et al. (2013, p.544) *logic of extrapolation* which defines trust expressed towards the EU as being derived from one's general standing towards political institutions or tangent to individual personality traits. The idea behind the logic of extrapolation, is that trust *does not necessarily depend on characteristics of the object itself* Harteveld, et al.(2013, p.546), but could be conditioned upon individual perceptions and experiences with more broadly defined institutions. In that understanding, trust towards the EU is likely interlinked with other dimensions of institutional trust.

Second, although we anticipate that institutional trust is primarily influenced by individual-level factors, such as income, education, and employment, it is still imperative to examine regional-level cohesion and agricultural funding. EU redistribution is specifically intended to function at the national level, so NUTS2 allocations serve as the institutional means of enacting supranational solidarity. Ignoring these transfers' influence on individuals would overlook a central policy instrument of the EU. Additionally, regional funding may have contextual or indirect effects that are not fully captured by individual covariates, such as influencing local economic opportunities or, as Capello & Perucca (2019) put it, influencing the economy of residence. Moreover, the visibility requirement of EU funding suggests that citizens in high-funding regions are more likely to encounter EU symbols and communication campaigns, which could potentially affect supranational trust, even if national trust remains resource-driven. Finally, the inclusion of regional variables enabled us to investigate whether redistributive instruments enhance or diminish legitimacy across governance levels, thereby connecting micro-level drivers with meso-level policy interventions.

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Data

The analysis combines two complementary datasets. Individual-level data is drawn from the European Social Survey (European Social Survey, 2002-2022), which provides harmonised cross-national survey data on individual attitudes for European countries, including Poland. To capture contextual influences, we complement the ESS with official policy data from the (European Commission, 2025a) for Poland covering the period 2008–2022, restricting the ESS to 2008-2022 accordingly[4]. We thus chose to adopt a single time frame, following the structure of the European Commission's data, which guided the temporal scope of our analysis. Furthermore, to reconcile the bi-annual ESS waves with annual cohesion funding data, we used the precise interview dates in the ESS, what allowed to match respondents to the corresponding calendar year, enabling the linkage with annual cohesion funding data.

Operationalisation

The dependent variables are latent factor scores constructed through Confirmatory Factor Analysis (CFA) using items from the European Social Survey(2002-2022) survey. The first model estimates associations on *TrustNatCFA*, representing trust in national institutions (politicians, parliament, political parties), while the second model dependent variable is *TrustSprnCFA*, representing trust in supranational institutions such as the European Parliament and the United Nations due to their shared variance. We combine trust in the EU Parliament and trust in the UN into a single factor because both items capture attitudes toward supranational institutions rather than national politics and have a relatively high correlation (r = 0.69), which indicates they share a common dimension of generalized supranational trust what aligns with the logic of extrapolation proposed by Harteveld, et al. (2013, p.544). While in essence, the factor is broader than pure attitudes towards the EU, or Euroscepticism, it plausibly captures a dimension of trust towards the EU insofar as low trust in supranational institutions overlaps with distrust towards the EU itself. This operationalisation reflects the limitations of the ESS dataset, which does not provide alternative indicators that could serve as a better approximation for trust towards the EU as a distinct conceptual polity.

Independent variables are drawn from the (European Social Survey, 2002-2022) and include gender (*gndr*), education (*eisced*), age (*agea*), household income (*hinctnta*), short-term unemployment (*uemp3m*), self-reported residence (*domicil),* and subjective social class (*class5*). Year fixed effects are included to absorb temporal shocks. Residence category (*domicil*) serves as our proxy for individual exposure to EAFRD transfers, particularly when interacted with the funding category. Neither the (European Social Survey, 2002-2022) nor (European Commission, 2025a) data capture direct exposure to EU agricultural funding; the self-reported residence of the respondents provides the best available approximation of who is most likely to be exposed to these transfers. Therefore, we include interaction terms to capture heterogeneous effects, interacting residence category (*domicil)* with EAFRD allocations enables us to proxy exposure to agricultural transfers and assess how living environment conditions their influence on trust. We thus matched the survey

[4] Poland joined the EU in 2004 and therefore absorbed EAFRD funds only in the latter part of the 2000–2006 programming period. As that caused a substantial missing data on EAFRD transfers, the analysis begins with the 2007–2013 period.

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respondents with the annual funding category of their region of residence (region-year). In that way, each ESS respondent inherits the funding band of their NUTS2 region in the interview year, providing a contextual measure of exposure to EAFRD absorption. Substantively, residing in a region assigned to a particular funding band indicates that the region has had that level of annual absorption within the reference period. The variable therefore functions as a contextual indicator of regional funding intensity, rather than as a measure of direct exposure, or the number and size of individual projects. This approach allows us to test whether variation in funding absorption correlates with differences in trust, but it cannot fully disentangle the mechanisms through which CAP funding is experienced. We therefore interpret the results as indicative of contextual association, rather than definitive individual effect, and emphasize the need for complementary qualitative evidence and in-depth designated survey data to capture the lived experience with the EU support. We still argue for this approach to be justified by the design of EAFRD, which targets rural and farm households, and by the visibility of this funding in rural contexts. We acknowledge that this proxy is imperfect, but it offers a meaningful way to capture heterogeneity in exposure to EU agricultural redistribution. We also restrict interaction terms to EAFRD allocations, as this fund is directly targeted at rural and farm households and shows significant effects in our models. However, to account for broader redistributive framework the empirical models include all major EU funds: Cohesion Fund (CF), European Social Fund (ESF), and European Regional Development Fund (ERDF). That allowed to see the overall dynamic of the type of provided funding on both national and supranational institutional trust. Yet, once regional fixed effects are included neither ESF nor CF exhibit significant associations, so we treat them as controls.

Estimation Method

Capturing the effect of EU cohesion allocations on individual-level institutional trust is inherently challenging. Although the broader literature on cohesion policy and political attitudes has greatly expanded (Ward, Tilley and Hobolt 2025; Charron and Rothstein 2018; Ubialia and Bagnini 2025), work that examines individual-level trust responses to EU agricultural allocations remains limited. Existing studies on the Polish case tend to focus on the impact of cohesion funding (Ambroziak 2014; Dziembała, 2021) with lesser focus on its link with institutional trust specifically (Dąbrowski 2008; Hartnett & Gard-Murray 2018). Owing to the risk of ecological fallacy and the vested difficulty of measuring direct exposure, several contributions (Charron and Rothstein 2018; López-Bazo 2022; Cataldo and Monastiriotis 2018) have adopted a strictly regional focus, though this necessarily comes at the expense of accounting for individual-level heterogeneity. Given the nature of our hypotheses and the available data, this study reports two complementary models to capture distinct dimensions of institutional trust. This dual-model strategy allows comparing how individual and regional characteristics shape trust in national political institutions versus supranational EU institutions, while ensuring that inter-error covariances are properly addressed. The first model uses the latent national political trust factor as the dependent variable. The second model employs the latent supranational trust factor, reflecting attitudes toward supranational level institutions. Since these are two separate estimations, the

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numerical results cannot be directly compared[5] across these specifications, however, together they provide conceptual insight into the dynamics shaping trust in both national and supranational institutions. The general model form of our main specification is as follows:

$$\mathbf{TrustCFA}_{it} = \boldsymbol{\alpha} + \boldsymbol{\beta_1 X_{it}} + \boldsymbol{\beta_2 Z_{rt}} + \boldsymbol{\beta_3}(\boldsymbol{domicil_i} \times \boldsymbol{EAFRD_{rt}}) + \boldsymbol{\gamma_t} + \boldsymbol{\epsilon_{it}}$$

Both models incorporate sociodemographic individual level (i) controls X_{it} (gender, education, age, income, measure of short-term unemployment, and social class) alongside year (t) fixed effects (γ_t) to absorb common temporal shocks. To capture the role of EU agricultural transfers, we include annual payments (Z_{rt}) on regional level (r, NUTS2) from major structural funds (CF, EAFRD, ESF), dropping ERDF where multicollinearity is detected. We further explore the potential joint effects with an interaction term between self-reported residence category (*domicil*) and EAFRD allocations, which allows us to proxy individual exposure to agricultural transfers and assess heterogeneous effects across living contexts. Estimation is performed using robust standard errors (ϵ_{it}) to address the detected heteroscedasticity in residuals.

Findings

Results for National Level Institutional Trust

The estimation reveals several notable patterns in relation to national-level trust, as shown in Table 2. Education is consistently positive and statistically significant, indicating that higher levels of education are associated with greater trust in national institutions. Income also exerts a strong positive and significant effect, suggesting that individuals with higher earnings are more trusting. Unemployment status is highly significant, with those in employment reporting markedly higher trust levels. By contrast, age does not exert a significant effect, and gender is consistently insignificant. Occupational categories show some variation: small business owners exhibit higher trust, though significance is weaker than in the supranational models, while lower-grade service and unskilled workers display negative coefficients without statistical significance. Self-reported residence category is important: suburban residents show a positive effect in the full specification, whereas individuals in country villages and farms report significantly lower trust, with the farm category strongly negative once interactions are introduced[6]. These findings suggest that socioeconomic resources and place of residence are key determinants of national trust.

[Table 2. Estimated Coefficients from OLS Models (Author's Calculations, ESS 2008-2022)]

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Variable / Category	National Trust	Supranational Trust
Gender (female)	-0.0181 (0.0638)	0.0287 (0.0847)
Education	0.0684** (0.0273)	0.0448 (0.0361)

[5] To address limitations on inference, we estimated additional specifications which we discuss in the robustness check section, and which coefficients are reported in Table 8 and Table 9 in the Appendix.

[6] Stepwise OLS model specifications are presented in Table 6 (national-level trust) and Table 7 (supranational-level trust) in the Appendix.

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Variable / Category	National Trust	Supranational Trust
Age	-0.00241 (0.00197)	-0.00932*** (0.00260)
Income	0.0443*** (0.0124)	0.0928*** (0.0170)
Unemployment (no)	0.244*** (0.0673)	0.141 (0.0888)
Lower-grade service	-0.146 (0.113)	-0.144 (0.153)
Small business owners	0.225* (0.127)	0.276* (0.164)
Skilled workers	-0.0329 (0.112)	0.0536 (0.151)
Unskilled workers	-0.0787 (0.131)	-0.203 (0.177)
Suburbs	0.461* (0.247)	0.648*** (0.225)
Town	-0.0696 (0.111)	0.145 (0.147)
Country village	-0.341*** (0.116)	-0.271* (0.152)
Farm	-1.623*** (0.196)	-2.712*** (0.302)
EAFRD €40–79m	-0.149 (0.161)	0.325*** (0.107)
EAFRD €80–119m	-0.336* (0.187)	-0.443*** (0.143)
EAFRD €120–160m	0.105 (0.221)	-0.170 (0.294)
EAFRD >€161m	-0.242* (0.136)	0.248 (0.281)
Suburbs × EAFRD €40–79m	-0.125 (0.511)	-1.139** (0.560)
Suburbs × EAFRD €80–119m	-1.281** (0.601)	-1.171 (0.815)
Town × EAFRD >€161m	-0.272 (0.313)	-0.781** (0.365)
Village × EAFRD all bands	n.s.	n.s.
Farmhouse × EAFRD €40–79m	2.047*** (0.374),	3.232*** (0.601)
Farmhouse × EAFRD €80–119m	-1.083*** (0.311)	0.930** (0.434)
Year fixed effects	Y	Y
Region fixed effects	Y	Y
Observations	1,924	1,924

Robust standard errors in parentheses *** p<0.01, ** p<0.05, * p<0.1; n.s.= nonsignificant. Only statistically significant coefficients are reported for clarity. Tables 6 and 7 in the Appendix report the full set of model coefficients. Note: These models cannot be directly compared as they are separate estimations, each capturing distinct institutional trust dimensions (national vs. supranational). For comparative purposes, an additional estimation using seemingly unrelated regression (SURE) is reported in the appendix, Table 8.

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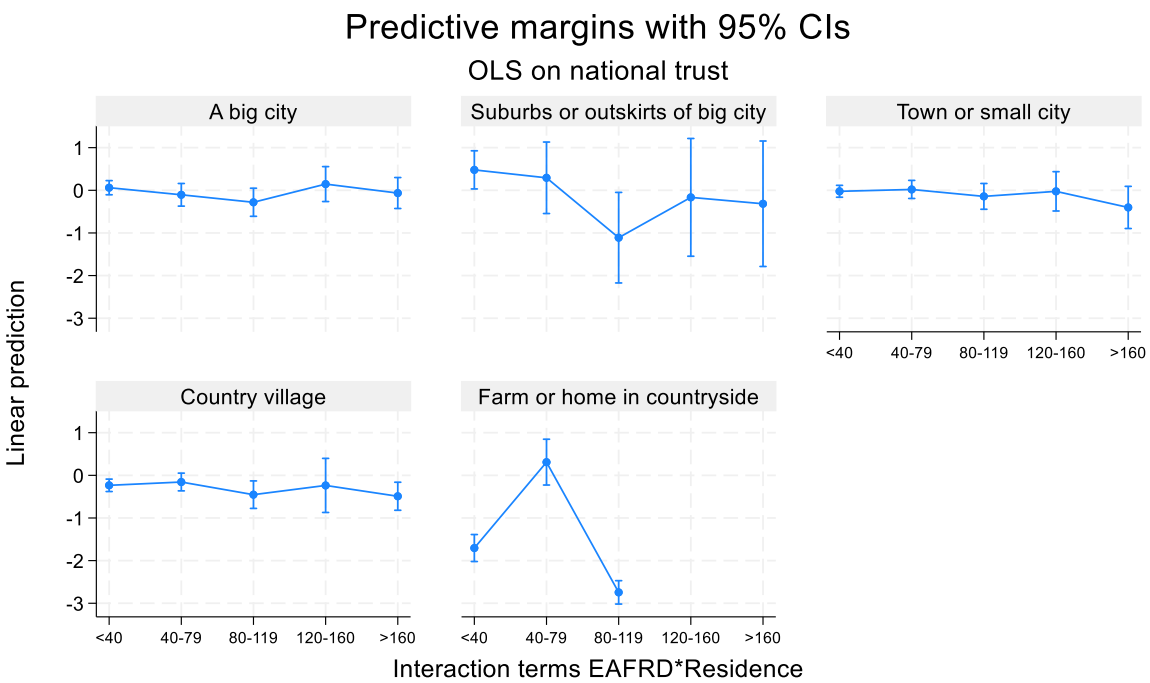
The coefficients for EAFRD allocations indicate a more muted, and at times negative, contextual association with individual trust in national institutions, particularly when contrasted with supranational trust. Residence in regions with moderate allocations (€40–79m) does not yield statistically significant effects, whereas residence in regions with allocations in the €80–119m band is consistently negative and significant, suggesting that intermediate levels of rural development funding are associated with reduced trust in national institutions. Residence in regions with the highest allocation band (>€161m) likewise corresponds to a negative coefficient for national trust. Collectively, these results imply that national-level trust is not straightforwardly strengthened by EU rural development funding; in some cases, larger allocations appear linked to heightened scepticism or perceptions of inefficiency. The interaction terms highlight marked variation across settlement types in the contextual association between EAFRD allocations and individual trust in national institutions. In suburban areas, residence in regions with moderate-to-high allocations is linked to negative effects, with the €80–119m band producing a statistically significant reduction in predicted trust. Towns and villages display no consistent significant interactions, suggesting that EU funding does not exert a strong contextual influence on national trust in these settings. Respondents in farm areas, by contrast, exhibit markedly higher trust when living in regions with moderate allocations (€40–79m), with a coefficient above 2, indicating a substantial contextual association. However, for the €80–119m band, the analysis identifies a statistically significant negative association with national trust. For now, we have examined coefficient estimates, which summarise the overall patterns in the data. To further evaluate the heterogeneity of these associations across funding intensities, we turn to the predictive margins.

[Figure 1 Estimated Predictive Margins from OLS Model of National Institutional Trust in Poland, own calculations using (European Social Survey, 2008-2022)]]



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The predictive margins as shown on Figure 1 indicate clear contextual variation in the model-predicted levels of national institutional trust across residence types and EAFRD funding bands. Among suburban residents, predicted trust is significantly higher in regions receiving less than €40 million, while other funding bands show no meaningful differences. In towns and small cities, predicted trust is also higher in the two lowest funding bands, with no notable deviations at higher levels. Country villages display a mixed pattern: moderate funding is associated with higher predicted trust, whereas the €80–119 million band yields a significantly lower predicted value. Farm and remote rural areas exhibit the largest departures, with very low predicted trust in the lowest funding band, positive incline in the mid-allocation, and further drastic reduction in the higher band (€80–119 million). Across funding bands, predicted trust among big-city residents shows no statistically significant variation. Overall, the predictive margins highlight a settlement-specific relationship in which the association between EAFRD funding intensity and national institutional trust varies across residence types.

Results for Supranational Level Institutional Trust

In contrast to the estimation on national trust, age emerge as a consistent predictor of institutional trust on the supranational level, with older respondents reporting significantly lower levels of trust and higher-income households reporting significantly greater trust. In line with the national level estimates, income shows a robust positive association with supranational trust, while the effect of small business ownership is consistently positive. The self-reported residence variable indicates lower trust outside urban centres, with a particularly pronounced, statistically significant negative coefficient for farms. When EU funding variables are introduced, the results point to divergent contextual associations with individual trust in supranational institutions. Residence in regions with moderate EAFRD allocations (€40–79m) is positively and significantly linked to higher trust, whereas allocations in the €80–119m band are negatively and significantly associated with lower trust. Other categories do not display consistent effects. The persistence of the age and income coefficients in this specification indicates that socioeconomic status continues to play a central role, while the funding results underscore that not all streams of EU support are perceived equally positively.

[Figure 2 Estimated Predictive Margins from OLS Model of Supranational Institutional Trust in Poland, own calculations using (European Social Survey, 2008-2022)]

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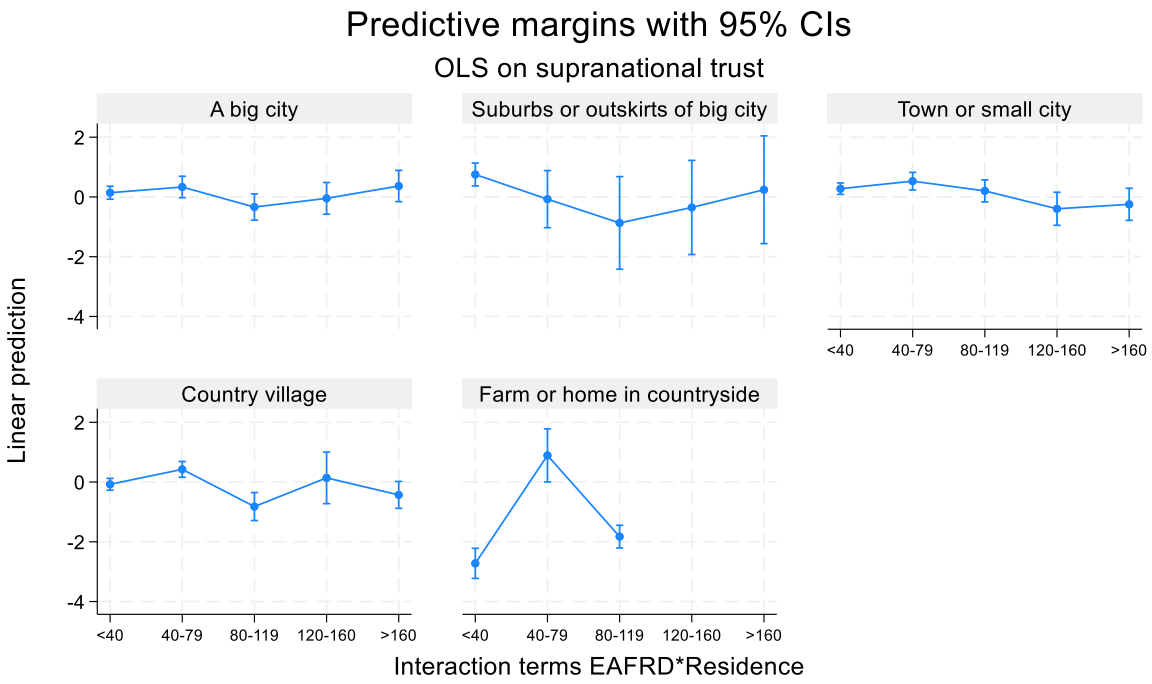

The predictive margins for supranational trust shown in Figure 2 reveal a more pronounced pattern than in the national-level results, with substantial variation across settlement types and EAFRD funding bands. Among suburban residents, predicted trust is notably higher in regions receiving less than €40 million, while other funding levels do not differ meaningfully within this residence category. Towns and small cities show a similar tendency: predicted trust is significantly higher in the two lowest funding bands, suggesting that smaller and mid-range allocations are associated with more favourable views of supranational institutions in these settings. In country villages, however, this positive association is short-lived. While the €40–79 million band corresponds to higher predicted trust, allocations in the €80–119 million range produce a sharp and significant decline, with a further marginally significant reduction at the highest funding levels. The most pronounced pattern is observed in farm and remote rural areas. Predicted trust is extremely low in the lowest funding band, rises significantly at €40–79 million, and then falls back into strong negatives at €80–119 million, suggesting a mixed response to supranational institutions in this residence category. Taken together, these results indicate that lower and mid-level EAFRD allocations are associated with higher supranational trust in suburban, town, and village settings, whereas higher allocations correspond to declining trust in rural and farm areas, underscoring a residence-specific, and likely non-linear relationship between funding intensity and supranational institutional trust.

Robustness checks

The comparison between OLS and SURE estimations shows a high degree of consistency, with coefficients retaining their direction and magnitude across both models.[7] While the national and supranational OLS

[7] Table 8 in the Appendix.

models cannot be directly compared given their separate specifications, SURE which estimates these two equations jointly allows for a more coherent comparison of coefficients across the national and supranational trust models, thereby reinforcing the stability of the OLS findings. For national trust, education, income, and employment remain positive and significant, while rural settlement types continue to exert negative effects, and the €80–119m EAFRD band confirms a negative relationship. Interaction terms, such as suburban × Band 3(€80–119m), also remain stable. For supranational trust, age remains a strong negative predictor, income a positive one, and settlement type effects (suburban positive, farm negative) are preserved, alongside the non-linear EAFRD band effects. In sum, SURE analysis confirms that the OLS findings are not driven by equation-specific error structures, reinforcing the robustness of the main specification.

Seemingly with the multilevel specification[8], the substantive conclusions remain comparable, with socio-demographic factors and EU funding exposure driving national trust, and year dummies capturing temporal shocks. However, the multilevel specification, which explicitly accounts for clustering at the regional level, reveals a significant negative association between Cohesion Fund (CF) allocations and national trust that is not apparent in the OLS model. We see that as illustrative of the nature of CF fund. The CF operates primarily at the regional level, and its allocation is determined through regional programming rather than individual targeting. Although this result is in line with the institutional design of the fund, it does not negate the correlations found in our primary specification, which focuses on factors that influence trust at the individual level. We therefore acknowledge the CF result as an important robustness check, but report the OLS estimates as the primary specification, given that substantive conclusions at the individual level remain unchanged across models.

Discussion

The findings offer clear support for H1, which proposes that material wellbeing is positively associated with institutional trust. Across both models, higher-income respondents exhibit significantly greater confidence in national and supranational institutions. The evidence we show for H2 is more nuanced. The hypothesis posited that a greater intensity of agricultural transfers would diminish trust, particularly at the national level, as it is possible that the transfers may be misallocated or the delivery process may be opaque. At the aggregate level, however, the results do not indicate a uniform decline. In the supranational model, lower-end allocations are associated with increased trust, whereas mid-range allocations correspond to a significant decrease in supranational trust. In addition, the negative pattern that manifests at the national level is broadly comparable, with mid-range and the highest allocations found to be negatively associated with trust. Further heterogeneity in the perception of agricultural redistribution is revealed by the interaction between residence type and funding band. Predictive margins indicate that suburban, and town settings with lower and mid-level allocations are generally associated with marginally higher predicted trust, whereas higher allocations are associated with declining trust in rural and farm areas at the supranational level. At the national level, predictive margins also indicated a negative pattern in rural contexts: country villages and farm households exhibit reduced trust across several funding bands, with the strongest scepticism evident among farm

[8] Table 9 in the Appendix.

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households in areas with mid-level financing. Residents of large cities exhibit minimal systematic variation across funding categories, while suburban areas exhibit a mixed profile, with some positive associations at lower allocations but declines at mid-range levels. These results indicate that the relationship under investigation is not linear, which is consistent with prior research on the subject (Borin, et al., 2021; López-Bazo, 2022). As a result, these correlations are thought to be very context-specific and differ depending on the type of residence and funding level. An overall picture seems to suggest that agricultural transfers begin to erode institutional trust once they reach moderate levels. Finally, the results support H3, the generational hypothesis. Supranational trust is significantly inversely correlated with age, with older people showing less faith in EU institutions than younger generations. Conversely, age does not exhibit any significant correlation with national trust, which is consistent with the notion that generational distinctions are pertinent primarily for supranational-level trust. This asymmetry emphasizes that generational divides are more closely associated with perceptions of the supranational polity than with evaluations of national governance.

That leads us to a discussion of the study limitations. Firstly, the study's scope was intentionally restricted to EAFRD payments in Poland during the second and third programming period. However, a more comprehensive comparative study of net-beneficiary member states could undoubtedly offer supplementary insights. Secondly, although cohesion funding is quantified at the NUTS2 level, local variations in project implementation granularity and citizens' awareness of EU investment may result in exposure and perception discrepancies. This is a recognised limitation in the empirical analysis of EU regional funding (Fiaschi, et al.). Subsequently, the inclusion of individuals who may not have encountered the visibility of instruments or tangible benefits of EU redistribution dilutes the estimated relationship between institutional trust and EAFRD funding. This indicates that the negative correlation we find for agricultural transfers does not represent the precise impact on individuals who are directly exposed to EU funds, but rather an average effect across the entire sample. To more accurately identify the mechanisms that link redistribution and trust, future research should incorporate measures of individual awareness and recognition of EU funding.

Alongside these caveats, we have sought to mitigate specific methodological concerns. The risk of ecological fallacy was mitigated by integrating individual-level ESS data with regional cohesion funding, rather than drawing conclusions about attitudes solely from aggregate indicators. We also accounted for temporal variation by including year fixed effects to strengthen the analysis and absorb shocks associated with external crises or political cycles. Finally, the use of CFA-derived latent trust factors with complementary robustness checks (multilevel models and SURE regressions) increases confidence in the reliability of the associations found, even though the observational design precludes strong causal claims. While these strategies reduce the risk of ecological fallacy, the results should be interpreted as associations between residence in regions with specific funding bands and individual trust, rather than as evidence of direct individual exposure to EU funds.

Finally, our analysis is limited by the inability to ascertain whether the negative correlation between agricultural funding and political trust is a result of actual misallocations or citizens' perceptions of unequal distribution. While redistributive politics literature emphasizes that transfers may undermine legitimacy when they are considered captured by elites or poorly targeted (Bachtler, Mendez, & Wishlade, 2013), our dataset

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does not include measures of how individuals perceive the fairness or effectiveness of EU funding. Rather, we depend on regional-level aggregate funding allocations, which quantify intensity but do not account for subjective evaluations. Consequently, the observed negative coefficients for agricultural payments may indicate either genuine inefficiencies in redistribution or a broader scepticism toward such transfers. However, we are unable to empirically disentangle these mechanisms. To determine whether misallocation perceptions contribute to the erosion of trust, future research should integrate qualitative evidence on local implementation or survey measures of perceived fairness.

Conclusion

Our study examines the broader EU's cohesion paradox in more detail, showing heterogeneous patterns of trust in national and supranational institutions across regions that received EAFRD funding in Poland. Drawing on material security (Hudson, 2006), redistributive politics (Devine, 2024), and generational dynamics (Abramson & Inglehart, 1992), we show that household income consistently enhances confidence across national and supranational levels of governance. Concurrently, the paradoxical negative impact of higher financial bands on agricultural transfers across our estimations underscores the political risks associated with redistributive policies when we expect their fairness or visibility may be called into question. Generational differences further distinguish supranational trust, with older cohorts expressing greater scepticism toward the EU. The study also demonstrated the potential for EU funding to influence citizen attitudes in an uneven manner. Despite substantial EU investment through EAFRD, individuals living in better funded regions do not exhibit higher trust in either national or supranational institutions. The patterns are suggesting that material support alone is insufficient to generate symbolic loyalty toward the EU. Lastly, these have explicit policy implications: redistributive instruments, such as agricultural payments, must be designed and communicated in a manner that enhances their legitimacy, while strategies to encourage supranational trust should consider the generational divides that undermine them.

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518

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